

UPSC PHILOSOPHY OPTIONAL

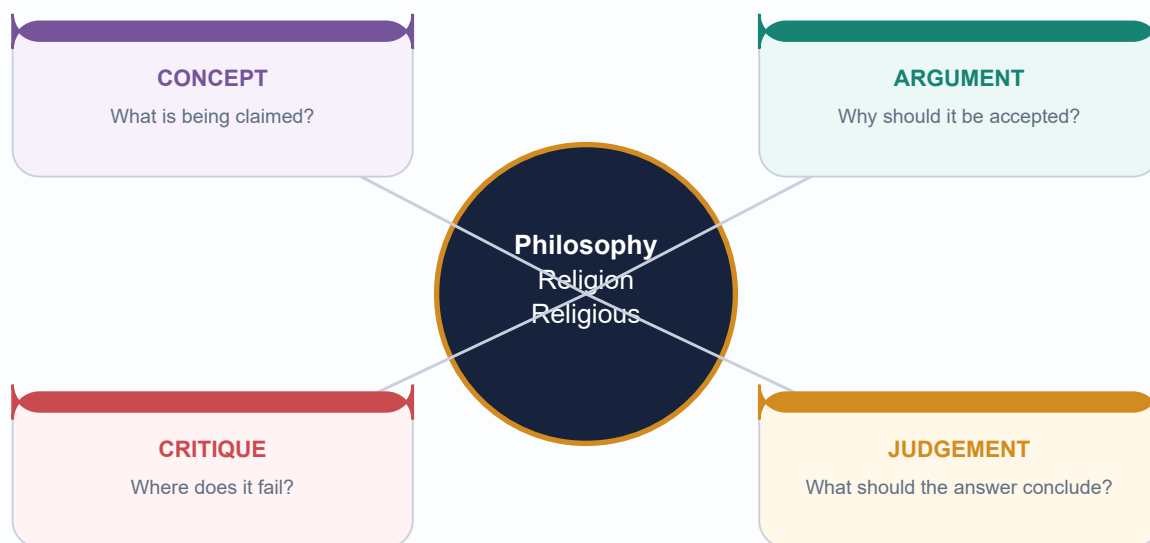
Philosophy of Religion: Religious Experience

UPSC Philosophy Optional | Paper II | Philosophy of Religion

Syllabus: Religious Experience: Nature and Object (Indian and Western).

Direct local-PDF base: Oxford Handbook, Mysticism and Religious Experience (PDF pp. 150-177); John Hick, local PDF discussions at pp. 86-92 and 120-130; Philosophy of Religion A-Z entries on James, Otto, mysticism and numinous experience; C. D. Sharma on anubhava and Vedanta. Cross-check: verified Paper-II knowledge note and verbatim 2022-2025 PYQ bank. The local collection lacks a searchable full text of Radhakrishnan's The Hindu View of Life; its treatment is therefore cross-checked through the verified knowledge note.

Content-rich visual edition: arguments, matrices, Indian perspectives, PYQs and answer frameworks



Facts from official sources | Inferences clearly marked | No fabricated data

HIGH UPSC RELEVANCE

HIGH

Master Experience Map: What Is Experienced as Sacred?

Paper II
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

Religious experience raises two questions: its phenomenological nature and its object. The experience may be theistic, numinous, non-dual or liberation-oriented, while its veridicality remains a further philosophical question.

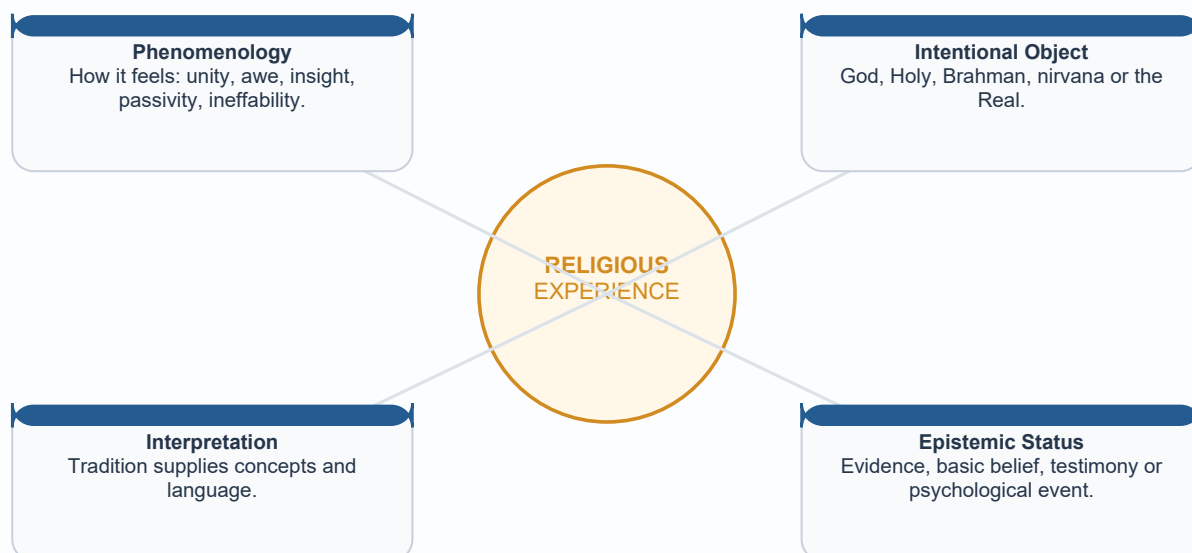
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NATURE, OBJECT AND WARRANT

EXPERIENCE CLAIMED AS CONTACT WITH ULTIMATE REALITY

James Ineffable, noetic, transient and passive mystical states.	Otto The numinous as <i>mysterium tremendum et fascinans</i> .
Schleiermacher Immediate feeling of absolute dependence.	Advaita Non-dual <i>aparoksanubhuti</i> : Atman is realised as Brahman.
Radhakrishnan Integral intuition of the Spirit; dogma interprets experience.	Veridicality Credulity, testimony and fruits versus naturalistic defeat.

EXPERIENCE-TO-BELIEF FLOW



STATIC THEORY

- **Nature/object distinction:** describing the experience does not yet prove what caused it or what it discloses.
- **James:** mystical states have a noetic quality and are judged pragmatically by their fruits.
- **Otto:** the numinous is non-rational awe combining overwhelming mystery and attraction.
- **Advaita:** the highest experience removes subject-object duality; Brahman is realised as the Self, not encountered as an external object.

MEMORY HOOK

PINT for James: Passive, Ineffable, Noetic, Transient. Then ask OBJECT and WARRANT.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Mystical experience is a narrower category than every religious emotion.
2. Ineffability concerns limits of expression, not absence of cognitive significance.
3. James gives personal experience priority over institutional religion.
4. Otto's tremendum and fascinans are simultaneous repulsion and attraction.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Religious experience is simply intense emotion.

CORRECT: Many accounts claim noetic or cognitive disclosure, not feeling alone.

WRONG: Ineffable means meaningless.

CORRECT: It marks discursive limits while preserving claimed insight.

SYLLABUS AND CONCEPT LINKS

Core Concept	Linked Debate	Answer Use
Experience as revelation	Reason, revelation and faith	Supports a non-propositional model of disclosure.
Ineffability	Religious language	Motivates analogy, symbol and negation.
Diverse experiences	Religious pluralism	Hick interprets them as culturally shaped responses to the Real.
Samadhi/anubhava	Yoga and Vedanta	Adds Indian phenomenology and soteriology.

MAINS ANGLE

Religious experience can provide prima facie personal warrant, but public proof of a uniquely specified object requires further argument.

STUDY LINK

Religious Experience: Nature and Object (Indian and Western).

HIGH

Core Concepts, Vocabulary and Internal Logic

Paper II
Philosophy

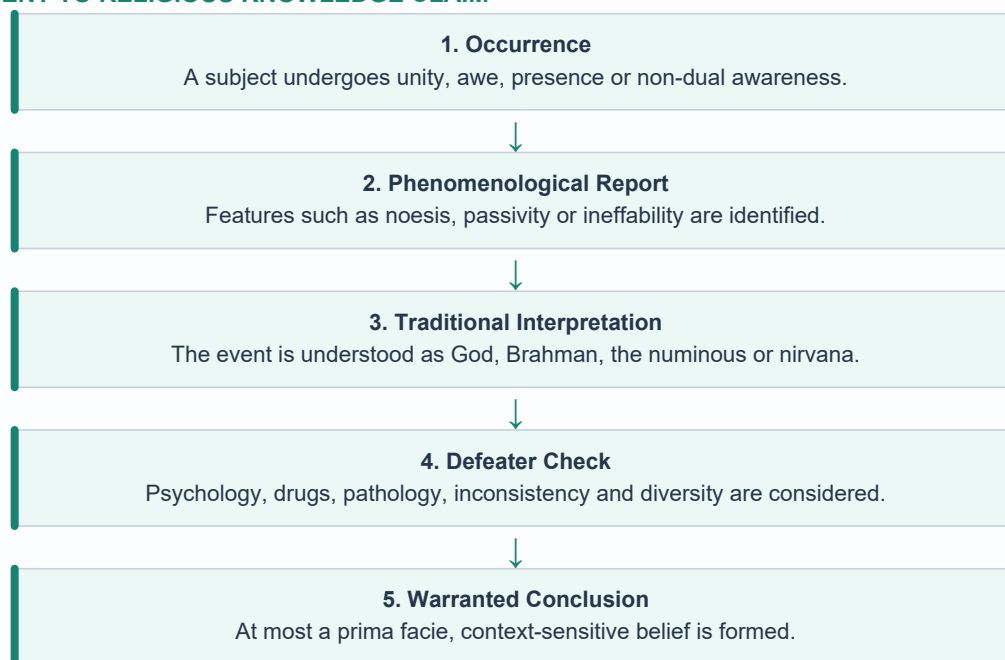
INTRO & ORIGIN

Phenomenology, interpretation and epistemic assessment must remain analytically distinct.

Definitions are followed by the argument's premises and conclusion so that the doctrine can be reconstructed rather than merely named.

KEY DATA

Term / Position	Precise Meaning	Exam Use
Ineffability	The state resists adequate verbal expression.	James and mystical language.
Noetic quality	The experience presents itself as insight or knowledge.	Distinguish cognition from emotion.
Transience	The state is brief and cannot be sustained indefinitely.	James's mark.
Passivity	The subject feels grasped by a power beyond ordinary will.	James's mark.
Numinous	Experience of the Holy as wholly other mystery.	Otto.
Aparoksanubhuti	Immediate non-mediated realisation.	Advaita and Radhakrishnan.
Principle of credulity	Appearances are prima facie trustworthy absent defeaters.	Swinburne-style warrant.

FROM EVENT TO RELIGIOUS KNOWLEDGE CLAIM**STATIC THEORY**

- **James's method:** begin with varieties of personal experience and evaluate consequences rather than impose one essence.
- **Otto's account:** the numinous is sui generis and irreducible to moral goodness or ordinary fear.
- **Radhakrishnan:** spiritual intuition is self-authenticating and integrative; doctrines are secondary conceptual formulations.
- **Mystical revelation:** an experience may disclose rather than verbally communicate, but interpretation remains unavoidable.

MEMORY HOOK

EVENT -> REPORT -> INTERPRETATION -> DEFEATERS -> WARRANT.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Advaitic experience is identity-realisation rather than a relation between subject and God.
2. The principle of credulity gives prima facie trust, not immunity from defeaters.
3. Religious diversity complicates inference from experience to one determinate object.

UPSC TRAPS

- WRONG:** Advaita describes a vision of an external Brahman.
- CORRECT:** It describes non-dual realisation of identity.
- WRONG:** Good moral fruits prove supernatural origin.
- CORRECT:** Fruits support significance but do not uniquely establish cause.

MAINS ANGLE

Immediate certainty for the subject does not automatically become intersubjective certainty for others.

STUDY LINK

Use this card for definition, exposition and premise-conclusion reconstruction.

HIGH**Classical, Contemporary and Indian Perspectives**Paper II
Philosophy**INTRO & ORIGIN**

A comparison should distinguish dualistic encounter from non-dual identity and phenomenology from ontology.

The comparison matrix keeps similarities and differences on the same axes; Indian positions are included where they alter the structure of the debate.

KEY DATA

Account	Nature of Experience	Claimed Object
William James	Ineffable, noetic, transient, passive; pragmatic fruits.	The MORE or higher reality.
Rudolf Otto	Non-rational awe: tremendum and fascinans.	The Holy / numinous.
Schleiermacher	Feeling of absolute dependence.	Infinite source of dependence.
Theistic mysticism	Loving union or communion retaining relation.	Personal God.
Advaita	Nirvikalpa non-duality and self-certifying awareness.	Brahman as one's own Self.
Radhakrishnan	Integral intuition unifying knower and Real.	Universal Spirit interpreted through traditions.

STATIC THEORY

- **Perennialist tendency:** diverse mystics share a common core beneath interpretation.
- **Constructivist tendency:** language, training and expectation shape even the experience itself.
- **Contemporary naturalism:** neuroscience may explain mechanisms without deciding whether the experience has a transcendent object.

MEMORY HOOK

DUAL / NON-DUAL; FELT / NOETIC; PRIVATE / PUBLIC: three axes.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Mechanistic explanation and metaphysical refutation are not identical.
2. The same phenomenology can receive different doctrinal interpretations.
3. Radhakrishnan uses experience to support universality without erasing traditions.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Assuming all mystics report identical content.

CORRECT: Similarity of structure does not erase doctrinal difference.

WRONG: Using neuroscience as an automatic disproof.

CORRECT: A neural correlate is expected for both veridical and non-veridical experience.

CROSS-PAPER ENRICHMENT

Paper-II Theme	Paper-I / Indian Link	Value Added
James	Pragmatism	Use fruits and lived transformation as tests.
Advaitic anubhava	Vedanta	Connect self-luminosity and non-duality.
Samadhi	Yoga	Compare disciplined altered consciousness and liberation.

MAINS ANGLE

Phenomenological convergence supports comparison, while object claims remain tradition-sensitive and philosophically contestable.

STUDY LINK

Deploy one Western and one Indian comparison only when it sharpens the question.

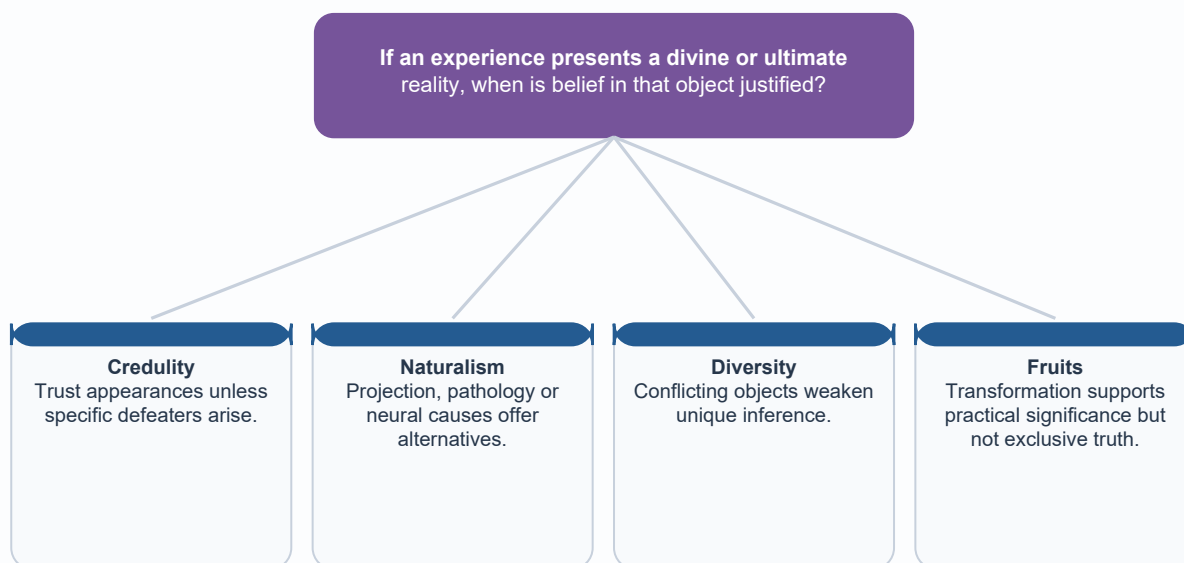
HIGH**Objections, Replies and Qualified Assessment**

Paper II
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

The main issue is whether religious experience justifies belief in a transcendent object or only reports a psychological state.

A strong answer presents the strongest objection in its best form, then tests the reply without treating either side as automatically decisive.

VERIDICALITY DEBATE

KEY DATA

Objection	Reply / Qualification	Final Assessment
Private experience cannot be evidence	Perception is also first-person and can ground testimony.	Public warrant is weaker but not zero.
Natural causes explain it away	Proximate mechanisms need not exclude transcendent causation.	Independent reasons are needed to choose between interpretations.
Conflicting experiences refute each other	Hick treats them as culturally mediated responses to one Real.	Pluralism saves common reference but risks an unknowable Real.
Ineffability blocks truth claims	Analogy and symbol can communicate partial content.	The more determinate the claim, the greater the evidential burden.
Self-certification is circular	Immediate awareness may be non-inferentially warranted.	Defeaters and intersubjective checks remain necessary.

STATIC THEORY

- **Principle of testimony:** reports deserve prima facie consideration but vary with reliability and background knowledge.
- **Pragmatic test:** enduring moral and existential transformation is relevant evidence of authenticity, not proof of metaphysics.
- **Pluralist reply:** object diversity may reflect conceptual lenses rather than wholly different ultimate realities.

MEMORY HOOK

PERSONAL WARRANT is not PUBLIC PROOF.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. The object of experience can be personal, impersonal or non-theistic.
2. A religious experience may function as revelation without containing propositions.
3. Authenticity, veridicality and doctrinal interpretation are separate questions.

UPSC TRAPS

- WRONG:** Rejecting experience because it is subjective.
CORRECT: Subjectivity alone does not remove epistemic value.
WRONG: Accepting experience because it is sincere.
CORRECT: Sincerity does not settle cause or object.

MAINS ANGLE

Religious experience is strongest as defeasible experiential warrant and weakest as a stand-alone proof of one exclusive theology.

STUDY LINK

Write criticism as a debate: objection, defence, residual difficulty.

HIGH

Verified PYQs and Applied Drills

Paper II
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

The following routes reproduce the verified demand of UPSC Philosophy Optional Paper II, Section B. Drills convert recurring formulations into practice prompts.

PYQ wording and marks are cross-checked against the local 2022-2025 question-paper PDFs and the verified _PYQ-PhilosophyOfReligion-2022-2025.md bank.

KEY DATA

Year / Marks	Verified PYQ Route	Core Demand
2022 / 15	Nature and variety of religious experiences according to William James.	Four marks, varieties and fruits.
2023 / 15	Relation between mystical experience and revelation.	Non-propositional disclosure and religious life.
2024 / 15	Main features of religious experience in Advaita Vedanta.	Non-duality, self-certification and ineffability.
2025 / 20	Nature and object of religious experience in Radhakrishnan's Hindu View of Life.	Integral intuition and universal Spirit.

STATIC THEORY

- **Applied drill 1:** Does the principle of credulity apply equally to contradictory religious experiences?
- **Applied drill 2:** Compare Otto's numinous with Advaita's non-dual awareness.
- **Applied drill 3:** Can moral transformation establish veridicality?
- **Applied drill 4:** Is ineffability compatible with the noetic quality?

MEMORY HOOK

Read the directive first: discuss = balanced exposition; examine = test the claim; critically evaluate = objection, reply and judgement.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Use the exact syllabus vocabulary in the introduction.
2. Distinguish exposition from evaluation with explicit transitions.
3. A statement question must first interpret the statement's philosophical assumption.
4. Never invent quotations; paraphrase unless wording is securely verified.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Listing thinkers without reconstructing their reasons.

CORRECT: Build at least one explicit premise-conclusion chain.

WRONG: Using Indian material as an ornamental final paragraph.

CORRECT: Integrate it where it changes the conceptual issue.

MAINS ANGLE

Answer nature and object separately, then add the veridicality question.

STUDY LINK

Revise the PYQ rows alongside the doctrine and dialectic cards.

HIGH

10/15/20-Mark Answer Frameworks

Paper II
Philosophy

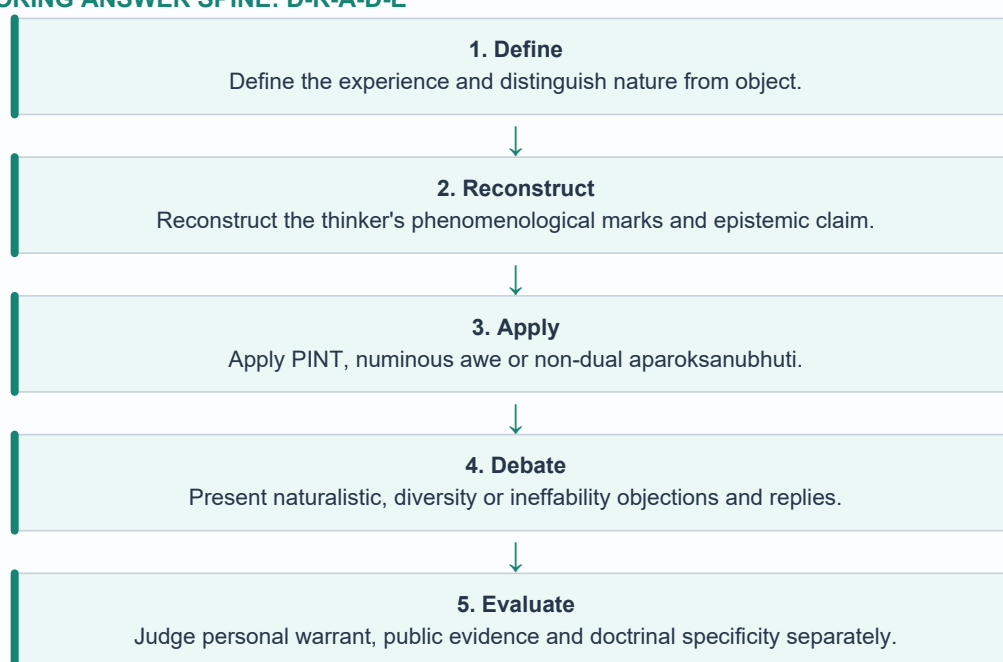
INTRO & ORIGIN

Answer length changes the depth of reconstruction and debate, not the accuracy of the doctrine. Every framework follows Define-Reconstruct-Apply-Debate-Evaluate.

These are answer architectures, not model answers to memorise verbatim.

KEY DATA

Marks	Recommended Architecture	Non-Negotiable
10	Define religious experience; explain one account's features and object; add one veridicality issue.	One precise distinction and one criticism.
15	Compare two phenomenologies; distinguish interpretation and object; test naturalistic and pluralist objections.	Internal logic, comparison and qualified judgement.
20	Map Western and Indian accounts; analyse nature/object/warrant; develop diversity and credulity debate; conclude on defeasible evidence.	Full dialectic, Indian-Western bridge and defended conclusion.

HIGH-SCORING ANSWER SPINE: D-R-A-D-E**STATIC THEORY**

- **James line:** test by fruits without confusing utility and truth.
- **Indian line:** Advaita's object is realised identity, not external presence.
- **Balanced close:** experiential immediacy gives force, interpretive mediation limits exclusivity.

MEMORY HOOK

Conclude: The experience warrants ____ for the subject, but establishes ____ publicly only when supported by ____.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. 10 marks: approximately 150 words; prioritise precision over range.
2. 15 marks: add one comparison and a developed objection-reply.
3. 20 marks: organise the answer around a philosophical problem, not a catalogue.
4. The conclusion must answer the exact necessity, possibility or truth claim asked.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Giving the same compressed answer for every mark value.

CORRECT: Increase depth of reconstruction, criticism and synthesis with marks.

WRONG: Ending with 'both views are important'.

CORRECT: State what survives criticism and under what qualification.

MAINS ANGLE

Religious experience can provide prima facie personal warrant, but public proof of a uniquely specified object requires further argument.

STUDY LINK

Final revision: master map -> argument -> comparison -> objection/reply -> PYQ answer spine.

End of Register Notes — UPSC Agent / Copilot CLI